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Title:

A Dozen Red Flags

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Publication Date: September 1, 2021

Published by

MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS

U.S.A.

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A DOZEN RED FLAGS

By Briana LaVine Leigh

Duo or Humorous Interp

ELIZA I mean, I guess I've never been, like, *thee* best judge of character. It's possible I have a slight tendency to assume people have good intentions. Don't get me wrong, I don't just trust anyone for no reason…….. but yeah the tattoo on his forearm of a naked woman being torn in half by a centaur probably should have been my first red flag. Aaaaaand perhaps the complete absence of any online identity...at all...should have been the second? And all of the tarps and concrete blocks in the backseat of his car? Who am I kidding, if a dude handed me a dozen red flags I'd be like "A dozen red flags?! For me?!"

INTRO

DELORES You've got to watch out for these new generation hippies-they've got these dumb names like Vistun, what is that? I saw one on the Price is Right yesterday, dreadlocks and everything, probably drinks tree milk and plays the bassoon, his name-get this Eliza- was Apple. What? Why? Back in my day-

ELIZA Yeah I know I know, back in your day everyone was intelligent and hard-working and made great choices all the time. [sarcastically] That's why the world was such a perfect place when I was born on September 12th, 2001.

DELORES Well see now that was unfortunate.

ELIZA Delores I've been working at the nursing home for three years, overtime most weeks, putting myself through nursing school, packing PB&J's to save money and being nice to you even though they don't pay me extra for that, so whoever you have in mind when you keep spouting off about "the young people these days" it's not me. I think you've been watching too much Jersey Shore.

DELORES You're a good girl Eliza, and I know you want to find that special boy, and the feet swept and bells at the church and nursery rhymes and all that schmaltz [she shudders] but land sakes you have terrible taste in men, and most men don't know their butt from their elbow to begin with.

ELIZA [to audience] Delores Yarmicheal was the youngest resident at Bright Horizons Nursing Home. She was completely capable of living on her own but had developed an addiction to her grandson's ADHD medication on a weeklong stay with her son in Yuma, when she accidentally popped his Adderall instead of her blood pressure medication [like a side note and with an eye roll] because she refuses to wear her readers. Suffice it to say, the adrenaline rush reminded her of her field research days as an archeologist in Guatemala and she was hooked. [Delores

mimes out the following] The jig was up when she stole a car from a lady parked in front of the Pharmacy, led police on a high-speed chase down Interstate 90 and saw some serious airtime hopping the overpass north of the Billington Target.

DELORES [at the scene of her arrest] Oh you think you're gonna arrest me with that tiny gun and your tiny handcuffs, I'm a Freedom Rider, you'll never cage me, coppers!

ELIZA The judge gave her the option of drug rehab or an elder care facility. Which is when she landed at Bright Horizons and took a liking to me for some reason. She would have been able to leave after 6 months but since her arrival she has [lists]: Started Cliff Wiggin's pants on fire after he called her sweet lips, stole a nursing assistant's iPad and used it to order cannabis gummies, which she shared with the entire nursing home Bridge Club

BRIDGE CLUB 1 [old person very high] Whoa
BRIDGE CLUB 2 [old person also very high] Yeah
BRIDGE CLUB 1 These...cars...are so different these days
BRIDGE CLUB 2 I think this is a fish tank...but I'm having trouble remembering what fish are supposed to look like.

ELIZA *And* sprayed our Chaplain down with a fire extinguisher when she overheard him telling the charge nurse that Delores might be possessed. But it was the last charge on her record, assault with a venomous snake, which is partially my fault, that tacked on most of the extra time. It all started when I went on a date with a guy I met in line at Petco. Dupree Milgrin. I think. I mean, not 'I think' like I don't know where we met, I think that's his name, but the forensics aren't back yet. Anyway [transition noise/song]

DUPREE [gruff voice, mysterious] I prefer long hair

ELIZA [tentative, looks around to see if he's talking to someone else] Um, excuse me?

DUPREE Cats

ELIZA [looks confused]

DUPREE Long-haired cats. [nods at the packages she's carrying, evidence of owning a cat] I prefer long hair on my cats.

ELIZA [laughs sweetly, like she is lucky he is talking to her] Oh, ha, I do have one long haired Maine Coon, but also a British Shorthair.

DUPREE I bet your cats don't have pretty hair like yours, and that smells as good as yours.

ELIZA [helplessly clueless] Oh thank you! I've been using a new conditioner with lemongrass; it's supposed to help keep the mosquitos away!

DUPREE Can I try it?

ELIZA [to audience] ok ok I know, it looks bad, and in retrospect I...should maybe hire some kind of filtering service to assess potential dates...a first date at the city zoo...at 2 a.m. when the zoo is closed...but I thought maybe he worked there, or there was some kind of moonlight special? In my defense, I did tell people where I would be. Well, I told Delores. I knew my friends would get all crazy and flip out, but Delores was kind of stuck.

DELORES Like hell you're going on a first date with a psychopath in the middle of the night at the zoo. Did you at least get his plates? I got a guy who can run the plates.

ELIZA I hadn't thought about looking at his license plates. Besides, it's not nice to judge-isn't that what they tell us all growing up, don't judge a person until you walk a mile in their parole ankle bracelet? For all I knew this could be the best night of my whole life!

DUPREE I bet you're wondering why I asked you to meet me at the closed zoo, at 2 am on a Tuesday.

ELIZA Nope!

DUPREE [crazy eye, shaking his head yes] Perfect. This is the best time to...see...the animals that... sleep during the day? [he diverts his eyes to avoid giving himself away] Grab the blue flashlight off my dash.

ELIZA Dupree, or whatever his name is, crept stealthily to the main zoo gate with a crowbar and two screwdrivers. He probably saw something that needed to be fixed. As I clicked on the flashlight I caught a glimpse of the contents of his SUV. A large ultraviolet light, metal bowls, thermometers, a few concrete blocks and tarps. His passenger side seat was filled with tiny Ziplock bags with some kind of seeds in them. At this point I started to second guess my decision-making paradigm. Maybe I should have worn my tennis shoes.

DUPREE K LIZA, QUICK. It's totally cool that we're here. My friend um Jack, he works here. Yeah. I just don't want to...trip the cameras, I mean the motion sensors...the light sensors-cuz ahhh the lights come on and wake up...animals.

ELIZA It was actually a really nice time. He didn't say much but I told him about my cats and the goldfish and sugar gliders who hated the cats. The moon was full and bright, so every once in a while Dupree would stop suddenly, freeze, and be like " flashlight off NOW" so that we could just see things in the moonlight. He had me walk a very particular path that he said had the best lighting, which was sweet. He kept looking up at the light poles and doing these funky dance move things [make a move like you're avoiding a motion detector] He was super interested in this one enclosure in particular. I was trying to read the sign when Dupree suddenly disappeared into the bushes and reappeared with a large, flat four-wheeled cart.

DUPREE Weird, they just left this cart sitting here. [grabs stomach suddenly] Oh gosh, I'm feeling that burrito from earlier.

ELIZA Oh no! I have some Alka seltzer in my purse-

DUPREE No that's ok, I just need you to run back to the gate, prop it really wide open and then ah...get in your car and leave. That way I can just run out and not be uh embarrassed.

ELIZA Look, I'm a nurse-and many people have mistaken appendix pain or gallbladder pain for food-related digestion issues, not to mention the possibility of kidney stones and-

DUPREE SHUT UP! I mean, sorry I just, ah, please hurry.

ELIZA I can understand being embarrassed about gas on a first date, but you really can never be too careful-so as I ran back to the gate I punched in the emergency services number to my cell, just in case he started in with the fever and chills. I jumped in my car and waited to be sure he arrived safely back at his vehicle. After a couple of excruciatingly long minutes Dupree came creeping down the cobblestone walkway of the zoo entrance pushing that same cart, the chain running from his belt to his wallet was clanking against the screwdrivers still in his pocket.

DUPREE [yell whisper] WHAT ARE YOU STILL DOING HERE?!!!

ELIZA [to audience] Well, his sudden change of temperament, along with his flushed face and watery eyes was all the evidence I needed to hit send on my cell phone. This man was obviously experiencing an acute attack of appendicitis and needed emergency medical help.

ELIZA I think the gas you are experiencing may actually be a medical emergency-it's ok, I am a trained professional!

DUPREE NOBODY COULD POSSIBLY BE THIS STUPID [pulls out a gun] GET IN THE CAR AN DRIVE AWAY NOW

ELIZA [to audience] I've seen people get ornery over appendix pain before, but this was a little ridiculous.

ELIZA Look Dupree, I already called for an ambulance, lay down flat and don't make any jarring movements.

DUPREE YOU WHAT? OH, YOU DUMB- [raises gun up to shoot, then jerks his head upward with a bewildered, startled look] WHAT THE [Delores is flying from the top of Eliza's car towards Dupree]

The following lines are delivered throughout the ensuing struggle between Eliza and Delores, in whichever order/combination suits the actor(s):

ELIZA Delores Yarmicheal-what were you doing in my trunk, leave that man alone, he's experiencing a medical emergency! [fights with Delores, trying to hold her back] Put down the fork! Watch out for the cart, Delores-you're going to trip-

DELORES Wanna a piece of this, you chicken liver schmear? HiYaaaaah. The only medical emergency he's going to have is when I stab him in the eyeball with this fork!

Eliza and Delores wrestle towards the cart, Delores falls/trips/lands on the cart

DUPREE NO NO NO, LADY BE CAREFUL

ELIZA See, would a monster be concerned about your welfare-wait what's that hissing sound?

DELORES Be careful with this??????? [she holds up the snake] Is the leatherhead bad boy afraid of a little tiny SNAKE? [she hurls the snake at Dupree and she and Eliza watch as Dupree is bitten by the snake and collapses-we watch their facial reactions to the sequence].

Pause, Delores is supremely satisfied with herself, Eliza is in horrified shock

ELIZA Delores Yarmicheal how in the heck? Where did you-how did you-

DELORES I snuck into your trunk during wheelchair Zumba-I had a bad feeling about this Eliza.

Police siren sounds

POLICE OFFICER Ma'am you're under the arrest for *possession of*, [thinks for a second] and *assault with* a venomous snake.

DELORES Oh it's just a Coastal Taipan you big sissy. Warning though, don't pick it up by its tail, they get really grouchy when you do that.

POLICE OFFICER Actually, could ah, could *you* put the snake back?

DELORES That's what she said

POLICE OFFICER Ma'am. Please.

Transition sound/song

ELIZA At the hearing it really looked like Delores was going to be called the hero of the day and see the charges dropped-but given her priors the judge was skeptical that our story was true

saying, and I quote, “There’s no way one woman could be that gullible and another that crazy, connected to a crime this weird, and be innocent.” To which Delores just had to reply

DELORES Well there’s no way a man could be that arrogant, that short, and that bald and not become a judge in the United States court system.

ELIZA So yeah, I think we’ll be in here for a while. But I’m thankful, I learned a valuable lesson about how to handle venomous snakes.

DELORES Aaaaaand?

ELIZA And to *not* trust my terrible instincts.

JAIL CELLMATE Hey lady, you smell of lemongrass...and snake skin.

ELIZA Oh my gosh thank you! That’s an interesting tattoo on your forearm-is that a naked woman being torn in half by a centaur?

NOTES:

For Duo:
Actor One would play Eliza, Bridge Club 2, Police Officer
Actor Two would play Delores, Bridge Club 1, Dupree, Jail Cellmate

Eliza- early twenties, perky and confident, strong willed but naive and a little ditsy. Could have a Wisconsin/Minnesota accent.

Delores- Elderly, feisty, fiery intense eyes, maybe a horse Bronx accent

Dupree- Crazy eyes, monotone course voice, slow and deliberate phrasing